

How should we determine what evaluation questions to ask in regard to an individual initiative (strategic evaluation)?

Strategic evaluation reframes ‘evaluation’ from a narrow, initiative-by-initiative approach into a search for the strategic knowledge a sector or setting needs. Instead of starting with the question ‘how do we evaluate this particular initiative’, it begins by asking ‘what evaluative information do we need to inform our highest-priority strategic decisions in this sector?’ It then selects, sizes, and sequences the evaluation of individual initiatives accordingly. This shift in thinking about evaluation requires changes in funding, governance, organizational culture, commissioning, resource allocation, and evaluator practice.

Taking a strategic evaluation approach requires a change in mindset for purchasers/funders and those commissioning evaluations. A key point is that evaluation resources should not be tied to particular initiatives and decisions about evaluation planning just made by evaluators working on individual initiatives. As much as possible, evaluation resources should be pooled and regarded as one large Research and Development (R&D) fund, used to answer priority strategic questions necessary for deciding what to do next in the sector. It is a mistake to believe that all initiatives should be comprehensively evaluated, for instance, using impact evaluation. As pointed out in the Full Initiative Roll-Out Versus Piloting Evaluation Explainer (G16), in many real-world cases, impact evaluation is not undertaken on the full roll-out of a large-scale initiative because it is not feasible or affordable. When piloting has shown an initiative works, lower levels of monitoring and evaluation are used.

A strategic evaluation approach requires an institutional framework for stakeholders, decision-makers, and subject experts to identify the key strategic evaluation questions needed to move forward. These then need to drive the specific evaluation questions and types of evaluation used with individual initiatives. A permanent high-level Strategic Evaluation Oversight Group should be set up to determine priority evaluation questions and which should be answered by evaluating specific initiatives. The Strategic Evaluation Approach Tool (G2) sets out the steps for strategic evaluation. Many steps in strategic evaluation use other DoView Planning tools, for instance, Mapping a Set of Evaluation Questions Onto a DoView Strategy/Outcomes Diagram (G7).